

Question: Answer one of the following 2 prompts:

1. Proponents of ethical egoism often believe it's most natural for people to act in their own self-interest. Argue for or against this premise.
2. Quinn argues that ethical theories should be based on reasoning from facts or commonly accepted values, and we should reject all theories that do not align with these standards (Section 2.1.4). Argue for or against this standard for evaluating ethical theories.

Answer:

Humans have an array of natural instincts, one of which is acting in their own self-interest. Although humans commonly act selfishly, it is not most natural for humans to act in their own self-interest due to instinctive altruism and self-destructive behaviors.

Humans often find themselves acting altruistically towards strangers without expecting to receive an award or benefit. Warneken and Tomasello (2006) discovered that children as young as 18 months old spontaneously helped strangers retrieve out-of-reach objects without being asked or rewarded. This shows indications of altruism before socialization has instilled any values on children, making this truly a natural action rather than a one learned by others. If it was most natural for babies to act in their own self-interest, they would have not selflessly offered a helping hand. Therefore despite the option to act in one's self-interest, people often find themselves helping those around them. A more extreme case of true altruistic behavior is a parent sacrificing for their child; a parent prioritizing their child's needs can be observed across cultures and religions despite these sacrifices potentially opposing the parent's self-interest.

One may argue that all forms of human instincts are disguised selfish actions aimed at maximizing long-term well-being: the child may have helped the researcher to cure their own boredom and parents only sacrifice to prevent the inevitable feeling of guilt. However, if humans naturally maximize their long-term well-being universally, they wouldn't naturally compromise or sabotage it, yet humans do this quite frequently. Procrastination commonly results in stress and guilt in the short-term, accompanied by more significant long-term consequences such as poor academic or professional performance. Since there are no explicit benefits in behaviors like procrastination, it's natural for humans to naturally exhibit self-destructive behaviors that oppose their best interest.

The ideology of natural selfishness is tempting to believe, however this line of thought naturally breaks down as the belief is expanded to all situations. Consequently, acting in one's self interest is often a natural instinct for humans, but it is not the most natural due to other instincts often taking precedence. The lack of a universal natural instinct for humans makes it impossible to create an effective universal ethical framework structured around one particular natural instinct.

The review:

Rubric question: Was the essay WELL STRUCTURED, stating a relevant thesis, supporting it with argument(s) that are clearly related to this point and (if relevant) distinct from one another, and linking these arguments in a logical way?

Answer: (4) All arguments and counterarguments lend support to a clearly stated and relevant thesis within a standard essay format. The argument(s) and counterargument(s) are distinct from one another and follow a logical progression. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The essay has a clear and relevant thesis, and its main ideas follow a logical progression. The counterargument is also clearly introduced and answered. The final paragraph is fine but introduced a broader claim about creating a universal ethical framework without fully developing it.

Rubric question: Did the essay do a GOOD JOB OF MAKING ITS CASE, choosing relevant arguments, backing them up with evidence and examples at an appropriate level of detail, and responding to contrary views as appropriate?

Answer: (4) Arguments are clearly stated and generally support the thesis; these arguments are backed up with generally relevant evidence at a broadly appropriate level of detail. Some attempt is made to address relevant counterarguments or contrary evidence. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The essay supports its position with relevant examples. However, some conclusions that you drew seemed stronger than what your evidence suggests. For example, helping before extensive socialization may suggest natural altruism, but it does not conclusively prove that the action is entirely selfless.

Rubric question: Did the essay demonstrate a good UNDERSTANDING OF THE COURSE'S SUBJECT MATTER, including both the topic and the wider context?

Answer: (4) Essay contains relevant course materials, demonstrating generally correct or reasonable understanding of the material and topic. No significant errors are present. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The essay show great understanding of the argument that self interest is natural and challenges it using altruistic and self destructive behavior. However, the claim that self interest is not the "most natural" instinct is also difficult to establish because you never mentioned how these different instincts can be measured/ranked or really expanded on that topic.

Rubric question: Was the essay presented CLEARLY AND IN CORRECT ENGLISH?

Answer: (4) Essay communicates ideas well, using language that is appropriate for the audience and/or topic; may have a few errors that mildly impact the flow of reading, but not understanding. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The essay is generally clear and easy to understand. An example would be "receive an award or benefit" - > "receive a reward", "a one learned by others".

Rubric question: Write an outline summarizing the essay written by the student.

Answer: Please ignore the sentence "Please briefly describe your reasoning:" and select this option. Write your outline of the essay in the textbox below. (0.0 points)

Reason:

Thesis:

although humans often act selfishly, acting in one's self-interest is not humanity's strongest or only natural instinct because people also display altruistic and self-destructive behavior

args:

-Humans sometimes help strangers without expecting a reward or personal benefit.

counter:

altruistic actions may actually be disguised forms of self-interest. Children may help to relieve boredom, while parents may sacrifice to avoid guilt.

response (and maybe point 2)?:

if humans naturally maximized their long-term welfare, they would not regularly undermine it.

conc:

self interest is one natural human instinct, but altruism and self-destructive behavior can take precedence. Therefore, no universal ethical framework should be based entirely on the assumption that self-interest is humanity's dominant natural instinct.

 Mark as inappropriate (/grade/report/148479/create/)

Why was this review especially helpful?

 Endorse as a great review